

Employee goal orientation and knowledge sharing: the moderating effect of leader boundary spanning behavior

Goal
orientation and
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sharing

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Received 25 May 2023
Revised 26 July 2023
Accepted 4 September 2023

Abstract

Purpose – The research aims to examine the impacts of two different types of goal orientation, i.e. learning goal orientation (LGO) and performance-prove goal orientation (PPGO), on employee knowledge sharing, and whether these relationships are altered by leaders' boundary spanning behavior (BSB).

Design/methodology/approach – A sample of 170 employees and 93 leaders were collected from South Korean organizations. Data were analyzed using path analysis.

Findings – The results demonstrated that employees with a high LGO are more likely to engage in knowledge sharing, while employees with a high PPGO are less likely to show knowledge sharing. Moreover, the findings showed that highly learning oriented employees tend to engage in knowledge sharing when they are under leaders who show active BSB.

Practical implications – To encourage knowledge sharing between employees, organizations need to promote a mastery-structured work environment to help employees develop a stronger LGO. Also, organizations could benefit from implementing training programs for leaders that promote their BSB.

Originality/value – The research aims to provide a more articulate account for how LGO and PPGO affect employee knowledge sharing in opposite ways. More importantly, this research provides new insights regarding the role of leaders' BSB as a contextual factor in promoting employee knowledge sharing. Using social learning theory as a theoretical framework, this study indicates how employees with a high LGO learn the behaviors of boundary spanning leaders and are more willing to engage in knowledge sharing.

Keywords Knowledge sharing behavior, Goal orientation, Leader boundary spanning behavior, Social learning theory, Interactionist perspective

Paper type Research paper

In a competitive and dynamic business environment, knowledge sharing is critical for organizations to achieve sustainable competitive advantages (Rao Jada *et al.*, 2019; Yoon *et al.*, 2020). Knowledge sharing defined as the action of making knowledge available to others within the organizations such as providing or receiving task information, know-how, and feedback regarding a product or procedure is widely known to contribute to performance, innovation, organizational learning, and even long-term success (Yoon *et al.*, 2020; Wang and Noe, 2010). Recognizing the importance of knowledge sharing as a primary source of organizational competitive advantages, scholars have continuously conducted research to explore what promotes knowledge sharing between employees, which is an essential way to exploit an existing knowledge in the organizations (Rao Jada *et al.*, 2019).

Interestingly, the major obstacles for organizations to implement successful knowledge management systems were not the systems but individual employees (e.g. Lee *et al.*, 2015). Since knowledge is a source of power and competitive advantages for each employee, sharing knowledge is undoubtedly challenging for them unless they have compelling reasons or motivations to engage in such behavior (e.g. Kim *et al.*, 2016). As each individual is a primary entity that initiates knowledge sharing in an organization (Yoon *et al.*, 2020), we focus on



Leadership & Organization
Development Journal
Vol. 44 No. 7, 2023
pp. 927-939
© Emerald Publishing Limited
0143-7739
DOI 10.1108/LODJ-05-2023-0268

individual characteristics as potential predictors of employees' knowledge sharing. Particularly, we select goal orientation dimensions such as learning goal orientation (LGO) and performance-prove goal orientation (PPGO) as key predictors of employee knowledge sharing given their approach component in common (Elliot and Church, 1997), yet differing tendencies toward knowledge sharing.

Goal orientation refers to a motivational orientation that directs individuals' attention and effort on how to approach, interpret, and respond to achievement situations (Vandewalle *et al.*, 2019). Goal orientation has been known to be a potent antecedent of various individual attitudes and behaviors across diverse organizational settings (e.g. Stasielowicz, 2019). As a motivational force of behaviors, goal orientation is expected to influence individuals' reactions to achievement situations (DeShon and Gillespie, 2005), such as whether to engage in knowledge sharing at work. Considering the social aspect of most achievement settings in organizations, this study investigates the relationship between employee goal orientation and knowledge sharing, through exploring the different dimensions of goal orientation, such as LGO and PPGO. By empirically testing the effects of two types of goal orientation on employee knowledge sharing, we contribute to extant literature on goal orientation and knowledge sharing.

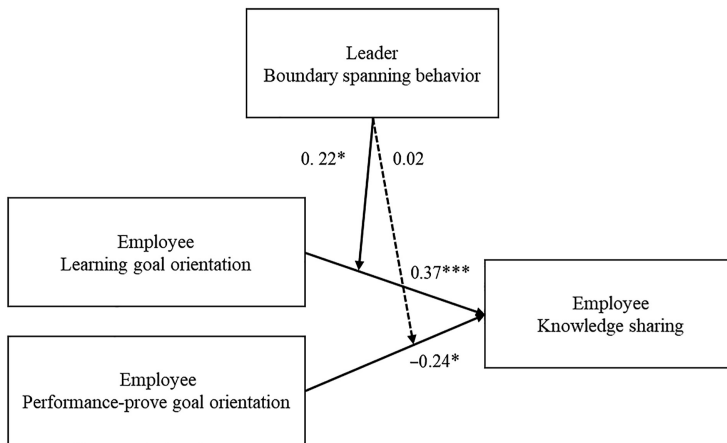
Moreover, we take an interactionist perspective and suggest a comprehensive narrative that integrates both personal and contextual factors to explain what makes employees to engage in knowledge sharing. A recent review paper by Vandewalle *et al.* (2019) called for more research on the roles of moderator variables in explicating the relationships between goal orientation and proximal and distal outcome variables, which enhances the potential predictive power of each goal orientation factor in organizational settings. To respond to such call, we introduce leaders' boundary spanning behavior (BSB) as a contextual factor, referring to leaders' activities to gain valuable information and knowledge beyond their units or organization (Salem *et al.*, 2018; Takanashi and Lee, 2019).

Although leaders are the ones who can connect with external parties and actually perform boundary-spanning activities, little research has explored the role of leaders' BSB that affects employees' attitudes and behaviors (Liu *et al.*, 2018; Marrone *et al.*, 2022; Zhang and Li, 2021). Given that knowledge sharing requires resources from an individual employee to engage, leaders' BSB could be an appropriate situational factor that can change the relationship between goal orientation and knowledge sharing by providing necessary resources. Importantly, boundary spanning leaders could act as a strong role model that influences how goal-oriented employees engage in knowledge sharing. Drawing upon social learning theory (Bandura, 1986), we expect leaders' BSB to strengthen the positive relationship between LGO and knowledge sharing, and to weaken the negative relationship between PPGO and knowledge sharing. Figure 1 illustrates our hypothesized model.

Theoretical background and hypotheses development

Goal orientation and knowledge sharing

Although knowledge sharing can occur at all different levels of organizations, such as between individuals, groups, departments, and organizations (Rao Jada *et al.*, 2019; Wang and Noe, 2010), we focus on the individual level knowledge sharing as any level of knowledge sharing requires the initiation or the participation of individuals (Yoon *et al.*, 2020). In fact, knowledge sharing mostly relies on each individual's willingness to share their knowledge (Yoon *et al.*, 2020). However, due to their concerns about losing the source of power and competitive advantages, employees tend to be reluctant to share their knowledge (e.g. Lee *et al.*, 2015). Thus, prior research has suggested various organizational-, leader-, and individual factors that predict and promote knowledge sharing (Wang and Noe, 2010).



Note(s): $n=170$ at employee level; $N=93$ at leader level. Unstandardized coefficients are presented. Only the solid lines represent the significant relationships

Source(s): Authors' work

Figure 1.
Path analysis results

Building upon the scholarly work on personality trait and motivation as the antecedents of knowledge sharing (e.g. Kim *et al.*, 2016), we expect goal orientation to serve as a powerful motivational drive for individuals to engage in more or less knowledge sharing in the workplace (Lee *et al.*, 2015). Because of its motivational drives, goal orientation guides individuals to engage in certain types of behaviors, either consciously or subconsciously (DeShon and Gillespie, 2005). We adopt the most widely accepted conceptualization of goal orientation that consists of three dimensions: LGO, PPGO, and performance-avoid goal orientation (PAGO) (Vandewalle *et al.*, 2019). Individuals with LGO focus on developing competences through mastering new skills in challenging situations. They believe that their ability can be developed through effort, which is an efficient strategy for improving performance. In contrast, individuals with PPGO and PAGO are mostly concerned with demonstrating their ability. Specifically, individuals with PPGO focus on demonstrating one's competence and gaining favorable judgments, while individuals with PAGO focus on avoiding negation of one's competence and negative judgments from others (Dweck and Leggett, 1988; Vandewalle *et al.*, 2019).

Given their relevance and different approaching tendencies, we select LGO and PPGO as key predictors of employee knowledge sharing. Depending on the types of goal orientation, employees would differ in the extent to which they engage in knowledge sharing because they tend to hold different beliefs about the possibility of ability development (e.g. Lee *et al.*, 2015). For example, LGO and PPGO are known to be related to different interpersonal styles and levels of interest in cooperation (Poortvliet and Giebels, 2012). Similarly, information sharing with colleagues can be regarded as a positive opportunity for mutual growth for individuals with a strong LGO; while it could be viewed as risky and problematic for individuals with a strong PPGO (Vandewalle *et al.*, 2019).

We expect that highly learning oriented employees are more likely to engage in knowledge sharing. Employees with a high LGO tend to select challenging tasks and skill improvement goals, and value experiences that provide growth (Vandewalle *et al.*, 2019). As they value challenging situations or tasks as a chance to develop their competencies by learning new and diverse information and knowledge, employees high in LGO would actively engage in

interactions with others at work through searching for, obtaining, and sharing new information and knowledge that might help them deal with the challenging situations or tasks. Also, they tend to perceive knowledge sharing as a learning experience, which deepens their own understanding and encourages them to find a better way to explain the knowledge before sharing it (e.g. Wang and Noe, 2010). For example, Lu *et al.* (2012) found the effects of LGO on innovative performance through knowledge sharing.

In contrast, we argue that employees with a high PPGO would be less likely to engage in knowledge sharing. Individuals holding a high PPGO assume challenging goals or tasks as a risk because they fear failing or revealing their inadequate ability to others. In fact, highly performance goal-oriented individuals are likely to respond to challenging tasks or difficult situations by avoiding challenges, showing little interest in difficult tasks, and putting little effort to succeed when facing adversity (Vandewalle *et al.*, 2019). As a result, employees high in PPGO tend to repeat experienced tasks that might help them prove their competence to others (Vandewalle *et al.*, 2019). As employees with a high PPGO are mostly concerned about their performance or outcomes rather than learning itself, they might not perceive any value for knowledge sharing.

Moreover, knowledge sharing can be costly for employees with a high PPGO because they can lose their competitive advantages to remain superior to others once their knowledge becomes available for everyone else in the organization for free. Those employees are sensitive to the possibility of losing their competitive advantages, as they are motivated to demonstrate their abilities to others (Zhu *et al.*, 2019). Unless they are confident that they are able to outperform others at work even after sharing their knowledge, they would not be willing to share their knowledge with others. Moreover, they may not want to waste their time and effort for knowledge sharing, which otherwise can be used for other work activities that might bring them greater personal benefits and rewards by outperforming others (Wang and Noe, 2010).

H1. Employee LGO is positively related to knowledge sharing.

H2. Employee PPGO is negatively related to knowledge sharing.

The moderating roles of leader boundary spanning behavior

BSB refers to actions taken by a focal individual or team reaching out into its environment to obtain important resources and support that might help accomplishing their objectives (Yao *et al.*, 2022), and are generally classified into three broad categories: representation, task coordination, and general information search (Marrone *et al.*, 2022). Importantly, boundary spanning underlies the survival and success of the team and its organization (Marrone *et al.*, 2022; Yao *et al.*, 2022). Prior research found BSB as one of significant antecedents of outcomes such as team knowledge sharing, innovativeness, and overall team effectiveness (Kou, 2021; Zhang and Li, 2021). Despite its importance, BSB at the individual level has not been studied sufficiently, especially for those who are in a leader position (Kim *et al.*, 2022).

Using a leadership approach “that creates direction, alignment, and commitment across boundaries in service of a higher goal” (Cross *et al.*, 2013, p. 81), we expect leaders’ BSB to exert significant influences over employees’ knowledge sharing. Leaders’ BSB is defined as actions undertaken by a leader reaching out into the surrounding environment to establish linkages with external parties, and to obtain important resources and support from the parties (Salem *et al.*, 2018). Given the vital power and position that leaders have in the workplace, they might act as key players in connecting with external parties and obtaining valuable resources from in- and out-group members, thereby exhibiting BSB (Takanashi and Lee, 2019). By serving an information-gathering function as well as an external representation function, leaders’ BSB can contribute to employee performance and creativity (Kim *et al.*, 2022; Takanashi and Lee, 2019).

Drawing upon social learning theory, we suggest leaders’ BSB as a critical context that might interact with goal orientation dimensions (i.e. LGO and PPGO) to affect employee

knowledge sharing. Social learning theory posits that individuals observe and imitate the behaviors of their role models (Bandura, 1986). In the workplace, employees tend to perceive their leaders as role models considering their higher position in social hierarchies (Lian *et al.*, 2022). As a role model, boundary spanning leaders can create a context in which individuals can “seek or give information, views, and ideas through interaction with other individuals” (Decuyper *et al.*, 2010, p. 118), and send signal to employees whether it is desirable to share information and knowledge with others.

As noted, due to the risk of losing competitive advantages coming from their expertise by sharing knowledge with others, employees tend to be reluctant to engage in knowledge sharing without an assurance of fair evaluation or an expectation of recognition by their leaders or the organization for doing it (e.g. Rao Jada *et al.*, 2019). Thus, depending on what their leaders pursue and expect them to achieve at work (Wang and Noe, 2010), employees may differ the extent to which they engage in knowledge sharing. Through a social learning process during which employees repeatedly observe and interact with their boundary spanning leaders, employees may perceive their knowledge sharing more positively because it is likely to be promoted by their boundary spanning leaders.

Under the supervision of boundary spanning leaders, employees high in LGO would be more likely to engage in knowledge sharing. By observing the behaviors of boundary spanning leaders, i.e. role modeling, employees high in LGO might learn the value of obtaining critical information or resources through interacting with external actors (Salem *et al.*, 2018), and thus be more motivated to imitate the behavior of searching for, obtaining, and sharing information and knowledge at work. Moreover, leaders’ BSB expands the amount and variety of information available to employees, allowing them to have additional information or resources for their work (Salem *et al.*, 2018). Since knowledge sharing consumes resources (Kim *et al.*, 2016; Yoon *et al.*, 2020), employees with a high LGO are more willing to share their knowledge when leaders provide valuable resources through their boundary spanning activities. We thus expect the positive relationship between employee LGO and knowledge sharing to become stronger when leaders highly engage in BSB.

When leaders engage in high levels of BSB, employees high in PPGO may also feel more comfortable to share their knowledge as this behavior is likely to be encouraged by their boundary spanning leaders. Due to the possibility of losing their competitive advantages by sharing knowledge, employees high in PPGO may find it difficult to take any interpersonal risks inherent in knowledge sharing unless their leaders show enough support and encouragement. Boundary spanning leaders, who tend to take on new opportunities and challenges, and frame their own setbacks as learning opportunities, can act as a role model that encourages employees to perceive the value of interacting with others for obtaining additional information and resources. Through observing and interacting with boundary spanning leaders who provide additional resources and support, employees with a high PPGO may receive signals from their leaders that it is desirable to share their valuable resources with others, which reduces their fear of failing at work.

- H3. Leader BSB moderates the relationship between employee LGO and knowledge sharing such that the positive relationship is stronger when leader BSB is at high than when it is at low.
- H4. Leader BSB moderates the relationship between employee PPGO and knowledge sharing such that the negative relationship is weaker when leader BSB is at high than when it is at low.

Method

Participants and procedures

We collected data from fifteen companies located in South Korea, from industries of mainly financial services, consulting and IT service. We designed two separate questionnaires: one for employees and the other for their direct leaders. When making a list of supervisor and subordinate pairs, our coordinators were informed that supervisor-subordinate dyads should be in appropriate position to evaluate subordinates' knowledge sharing and observe supervisors' boundary spanning behavior. Participation for this research was entirely voluntary. We informed participants the purpose of this study (in the cover letter) and assured that their responses would be kept confidential. They were asked to fill out the questionnaires and return them in the sealed envelopes. In total, 177 employees and 94 leaders returned their responses (89% of response rate). After deleting incomplete responses, our final sample consisting of 170 employees and 93 leaders was used in the final analysis. As for leaders, an average age was 42.97 years and 86% of them are male. As for employees, an average age was 34.01 years and 64% of them are male.

Measures

On a 7-point Likert-type scale ranging from 1 (*strongly disagree*) to 7 (*strongly agree*), leaders and employees indicated the extent to which they agree with each statement.

Goal orientation. Goal orientation was assessed by using the 13-item scale from Brett and VandeWalle (1999). Specifically, LGO was measured by five items (Cronbach alpha = 0.89), while PPGO was measured by four items (Cronbach alpha = 0.88). Sample items are "I am willing to select a challenging work assignment that I can learn a lot from" for LGO and "I try to figure out what it takes to prove my abilities to others at work" for PPGO.

Knowledge sharing. Leaders evaluated their employees' knowledge sharing using the 7-item scale developed by Srivastava *et al.* (2006). A sample item includes "This employee shares their special knowledge and expertise with others" (Cronbach alpha = 0.97).

Leader boundary spanning behavior (BSB). Leader BSB rated by his or her immediate subordinate was measured by using the 24-item scale developed by Ancona and Caldwell (1992). A sample item includes "My leader coordinates activities with external groups" (Cronbach alpha = 0.97).

Control variables. We controlled for demographic variables (age and gender) of both leaders and employees to rule out their potential influences on the study results (Kim *et al.*, 2017; Li *et al.*, 2022; Shen *et al.*, 2014). We also included PAGO as a control variable (Chen and Mathieu, 2008; Payne *et al.*, 2007), which was measured by four items from the scale developed by Brett and VandeWalle (1999) (Cronbach alpha = 0.82). A sample item for PAGO is "I prefer to avoid situations at work where I might perform poorly" [1].

Analytical strategy [2]

To test the hypotheses, we conducted a path analysis by using Mplus 8 with maximum likelihood estimation with robust standard errors (MLR) (Muthén and Muthén, 2012–2017), which was considered to handle a non-normality issue of the data. To take account of the non-independence of observations due to individuals' nesting within leader groups, we employed "Type = Complex" syntax in the analysis (e.g. Liu *et al.*, 2015).

Results

The means, standard deviations, reliability estimates, and inter-correlations of the study variables are shown in Table 1. The path analysis results are presented in Table 2.

Hypothesis 1 predicts the positive relationship between employee LGO and knowledge sharing. The result showed that employee LGO is positively related to knowledge sharing

Variable	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9
1 Employee age ^a	34.01	4.93									
2 Employee gender ^a	1.36	0.48	-0.37***								
3 Leader age ^b	42.97	4.28	0.37***	-0.26**							
4 Leader gender ^b	1.14	0.35	-0.13	0.24*	-0.47***						
5 Employee PAGO ^a	3.86	1.05	-0.11	0.08	-0.04	0.03	(0.82)				
6 Employee LGO ^a	5.05	0.84	0.05	-0.23***	0.17*	-0.12	-0.29***	(0.89)			
7 Employee PPGO ^a	5.21	0.84	-0.06	-0.03	0.09	-0.04	0.17*	0.49***	(0.88)		
8 Leader BSB	4.81	0.96	0.21**	-0.26**	0.02	-0.02	0.05	0.06	0.15*	(0.97)	
9 Employee knowledge sharing ^b	4.94	1.05	0.18*	-0.22*	0.08	-0.16	-0.16*	0.22*	-0.06	0.13	(0.97)

Note(s): *n* = 177 for employees and *N* = 94 for leaders. ^a Employee-rated variables. ^b Leader-rated variables. Age was measured in years and gender was dummy coded (1 = male, 2 = female). LGO = learning goal orientation; PPGO = performance-prove goal orientation; PAGO = performance-avoid goal orientation; BSB = boundary spanning behavior; Reliabilities were reported on the diagonal in parentheses

p* < 0.05, *p* < 0.01, ****p* < 0.001

Source(s): Authors' work

Table 1.
Descriptive statistics
and correlations of the
study variables

Table 2.
Path analysis results^a

	Employee knowledge sharing Estimate (S.E.)
Intercept	5.54*** (1.10)
Employee age	0.02 (0.02)
Employee gender	−0.18 (0.20)
Leader age	−0.02 (0.02)
Leader gender	−0.34 (0.28)
Employee PAGO	−0.02 (0.08)
Employee LGO	0.37*** (0.11)
Employee PPGO	−0.24* (0.11)
Leader BSB	0.01 (0.10)
Employee LGO × Leader BSB	0.22* (0.11)
Employee PPGO × Leader BSB	0.02 (0.11)

Note(s): $n = 170$ at employee level; $N = 93$ at leader level. ^a Entries are unstandardized coefficients. LGO = learning goal orientation; PPGO = performance-prove goal orientation; PAGO = performance-avoid goal orientation; BSB = boundary spanning behavior
* $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$ (two-tailed)
Source(s): Authors' work

($b = 0.37$, $SE = 0.11$, $p < 0.001$), thereby supporting [Hypothesis 1](#). [Hypothesis 2](#) posits that employee PPGO is negatively related to knowledge sharing. Our finding confirmed the negative relationship between PPGO and knowledge sharing ($b = -0.24$, $SE = 0.11$, $p < 0.05$), thereby supporting [Hypothesis 2](#) (see [Figure 1](#)).

[Hypothesis 3](#) posits the moderating effect of leader BSB in the relationship between employee LGO and knowledge sharing. The result found the significant interaction effect ($b = -0.22$, $SE = 0.11$, $p < 0.05$) ([Table 2](#)). [Figure 2](#) shows that the relationship between employee LGO and knowledge sharing was positive when the level of leader BSB was high (simple slope = 0.58, $t = 3.62$, $p < 0.001$), but the relationship was not significant when the level of leader BSB was low (simple slope = -0.16 , $t = 1.22$, *n.s.*). Thus, [Hypothesis 3](#) was supported.

[Hypothesis 4](#) predicts the moderating effect of leader BSB in the relationship between employee PPGO and knowledge sharing. Unlike our expectation, the interaction effect of employee PPGO and leader BSB on knowledge sharing was not significant ($b = 0.02$, $SE = 0.11$, *n.s.*). Therefore, [Hypothesis 4](#) was not supported.

Discussion

As knowledge sharing serves as a fundamental means for achieving organizational effectiveness, it is imperative to discover what factors affect employee knowledge sharing ([Kim et al., 2016](#); [Rao Jada et al., 2019](#)). We examined two different types of employee goal orientation simultaneously, i.e. LGO and PPGO, as predictors of knowledge sharing. According to our findings, employee LGO was positively related to knowledge sharing, while employee PPGO was negatively associated with knowledge sharing. Further, we tested the roles of leaders' BSB as a contextual factor that might alter such relationships and found that when leaders highly engage in BSB, learning-oriented employees are more likely to engage in knowledge sharing.

Unlike our expectation, leaders' BSB did not moderate the relationship between employee PPGO and knowledge sharing. There might be plausible reasons for this finding; it is possible that employees with a high PPGO may utilize the additional resources acquired from their boundary spanning leaders to increase their in-role performance rather than knowledge sharing. Although employees with a high PPGO possess sufficient resources, they may decide not to

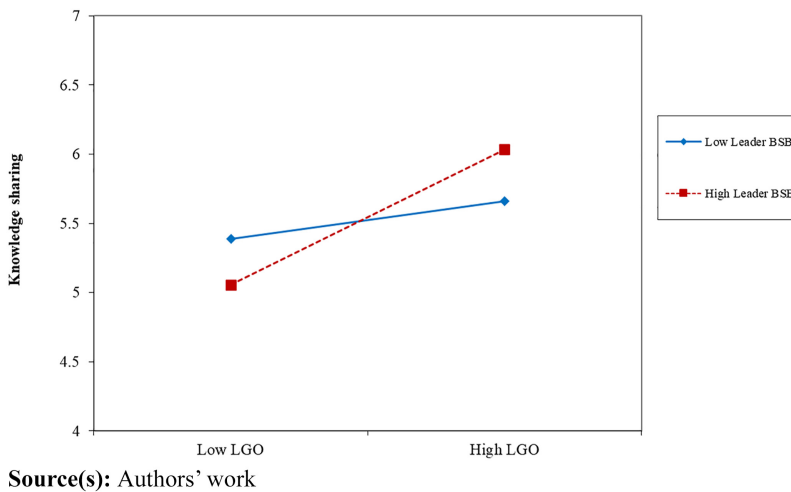


Figure 2.
The moderating effect
of leader BSB

engage in knowledge sharing, which seems as the least effective and safe way to fulfill their desire of demonstrating their competence. Also, leaders' BSB may not provide specific resources or support to motivate employees with a high PPGO to share their knowledge.

Theoretical implications

This study suggests several theoretical contributions. First, our research advances extant literature on the antecedents of knowledge sharing in organizations. Since knowledge sharing observed at any level of organization primarily arises from each individual's willingness and motivation to share, it is critical to understand what factors promote or hinder knowledge sharing at the individual level (Lee *et al.*, 2015). Scholars have noted the importance of personal predictors of knowledge sharing such as exchange ideology, hypercompetitiveness, self-efficacy, and openness to experience (e.g. Yoon *et al.*, 2020). This study thus focuses on goal orientation dimensions and provides an account for why LGO prompts knowledge sharing, while PPGO discourages knowledge sharing. Applying goal orientation theory (Dweck, 1986), this research provides a more articulate account for how LGO and PPGO affect employee knowledge sharing in opposite ways. By doing so, we suggest valuable insights into the role of goal orientation in explaining employee knowledge sharing in organizational contexts.

Taking an interactionist perspective, we further demonstrate the significant role of a leader's BSB as a contextual factor in promoting employee knowledge sharing. However, still more research is needed to explore various factors that might affect individuals' initiation to share their knowledge in organizations (e.g. Tan *et al.*, 2016). For example, incentives on knowledge sharing could be a possible moderator that alters the relationship between employee goal orientation dimensions and knowledge sharing.

Second, this study contributes to existing literature on leadership and boundary spanning by demonstrating the significant role of a leader's BSB that moderates the relationship between employee goal orientation dimensions and knowledge sharing. Prior studies have largely overlooked the complex dynamics of BSB undertaken by a leader, rather focused solely on team boundary spanning (e.g. Zhang and Li, 2021). Moreover, most existing leadership studies have focused on leaders' internal activities, such as empowering leadership and abusive supervision as predictors of employees' knowledge sharing (Kim

et al., 2016; Rao Jada *et al.*, 2019). Based on the existing body of work that mostly focuses on leaders' internal activities, we expand the scope of leadership literature by shifting a focus to leaders' external activities, i.e. BSB, as a potential contextual factor in our research model.

Using social learning theory as a theoretical framework, this study sheds light on how boundary spanning leaders act as a role model and influence the relationship between employee goal orientation dimensions and knowledge sharing. Our results demonstrate that employees with a high LGO learn the behaviors of boundary spanning leaders and are more willing to engage in knowledge sharing. However, the moderating role of leaders' BSB in the relationship between employee PPGO and knowledge sharing was not significant. This nonsignificant finding implies that employees with a high PPGO might be reluctant to share their knowledge with others unless leaders explicitly state that knowledge sharing is essential to be recognized as a high performer. In future research, it would be worthwhile to examine leaders' specific behaviors that might promote employees with a high PPGO to engage in knowledge sharing. Moreover, future research will benefit from demonstrating the direct effects of boundary spanning leadership on various employee outcomes.

Lastly, we extend the potential application of goal orientation research findings in organizational settings by providing empirical evidence with employees (Vandewalle *et al.*, 2019). By investigating the differentiated effects of LGO and PPGO on employee knowledge sharing, this study improves the understanding of the potential predictive power of each goal orientation dimension. According to Vandewalle *et al.* (2019), different from early goal orientation research that primarily focused on individual behaviors and performance outcomes, research in the past decade has expanded to include the study of interpersonal behaviors, which aligns with the contribution of this study for knowledge sharing. Future research should reveal the underlying mechanisms of how different goal orientation dimensions influence employees' knowledge sharing. With a stronger understanding of the impact of leaders' BSB as a moderator, we also broaden the scope in which goal orientation research findings are applied in the context of leadership. In future research, it is worthwhile to examine the moderating roles of different leader behaviors or leadership in the relationship between employee goal orientation dimensions and work outcomes.

Managerial implications

This study also suggests practical implications. First, to encourage knowledge exchange between employees, managers and organizations should be well aware of the importance of goal orientation that employees are holding and develop interventions to educate them about the potential benefits of holding a strong LGO. As our findings confirmed the positive effect of LGO and the negative effect of PPGO on knowledge sharing, managers might consider adjusting a selection procedure to account for employees with different characteristics and preferences, especially for the jobs that require and value knowledge sharing. Furthermore, managers could foster a learning culture that helps employees develop a stronger preference for developing competence, i.e. LGO (Vandewalle *et al.*, 2019). For example, acting as positive role models, managers could encourage employees to pursue new and challenging opportunities, provide useful feedback, and promote psychological safety (O'Keefe *et al.*, 2013; Vandewalle *et al.*, 2019).

Second, our findings suggest the importance of leader behaviors that match with the characteristics of employees to promote knowledge sharing. As learning goal oriented employees exhibit a high level of knowledge sharing in the context of a high level of leader BSB, organizations should consider matching team members with team leaders properly to stimulate knowledge sharing (Kristof-Brown *et al.*, 2005; Peng *et al.*, 2022).

Lastly, organizations could benefit from implementing training programs for leaders that promote their BSB. By adopting participatory and problem-solving approaches, these

training programs can educate leaders about how to effectively manage their work unit's relationships with its external environment for securing and obtaining necessary resources and information (Marrone *et al.*, 2022). It would be useful for leaders to gain practical knowledge about the potential impacts of their BSB on employees' work behaviors and performance.

Limitations and future research

This study is not without limitations. First, as we used cross-sectional data, common method bias can be a potential threat to our findings, especially when interpreting the causal relationships (Podsakoff *et al.*, 2003). Although the common method variance issue may bias our findings to some extent, the results of interaction effect would be less susceptible to such bias than are those concerning the main effect significance. Also, we collected data from different sources, including both leaders and employees, thereby addressing the common method bias issue to some degree.

Second, as this study only included a limited set of variables, further research should consider other potential factors that might affect the hypothesized relationships. Through incorporating more situational and relational variables, researchers would be able to obtain a more complete picture of knowledge sharing phenomenon in organization settings. For example, outcome interdependence or perceived motivational climate could be an important contextual factor that alters the relationship between employee goal orientation and knowledge sharing (e.g. Zhu *et al.*, 2019).

Notes

1. The authors conducted an additional path analysis without including any control variables, and the results were found consistent with the results from the hypothesized model.
2. The authors performed a series of confirmatory factor analyses to investigate the discriminant validity of the study variables. The values of fit indices suggested that the hypothesized four-factor model shows a good model fit to the data ($\chi^2 [164] = 251.41$ ($p < 0.001$), comparative fit index (CFI) = 0.97, Turkey–Lewis index (TLI) = 0.96, root-mean-square error of approximation (RMSEA) = 0.06) and fits the data better than the alternative models do.

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